

"We must preserve Ravi Varma's works, our nation's wealth."

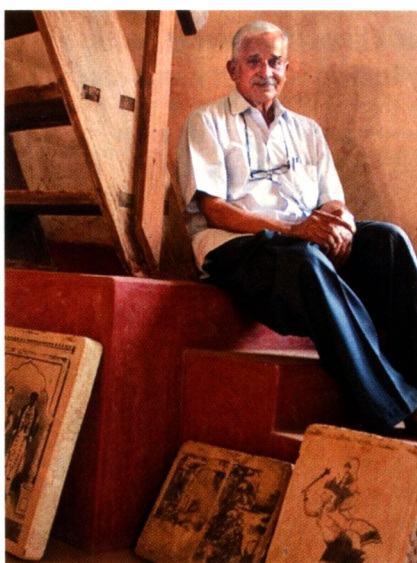
VIJAYNATH SHENOY, FOUNDER OF THE HASTA SHILPA TRUST

Schleicher's grandson Robert Sandu, the present owner of the property, who in spite of having refused countless artists and businessmen's entry into the property, disposed of the treasures to Shenoy.

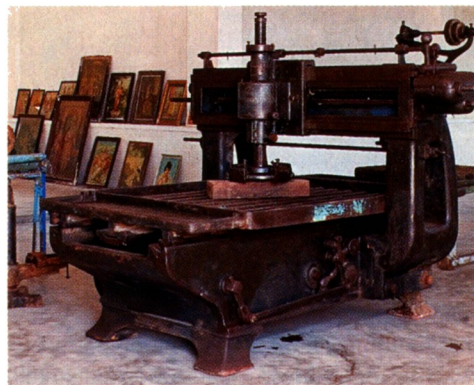
Indisputably India's great export in the field of art, Ravi Varma has been hailed as "the Michelangelo of India" for over a hundred years now. And it is the heritage of this artist that lay in ruins, uncared for and in a state of decay near Lonavala at Malavli in his printing press. It was time for individual if not collective action to take on the task of restoring this heritage. And, the man for the task was Shenoy.

It was Ravi Varma's death centenary in 2006. I was hoping something could be done by then, but the project was stalled for lack of resources," says Shenoy. While the Central Government, and its department of culture continued with its ostrich approach, the Royal Netherlands Embassy in Delhi came forward to provide financial support to the project. The Kerala Government followed up with its own plan of action, soon after, by announcing Ravi Varma's legacy was the legacy of the state and that nothing connected to it would be allowed to move out of the state. "There is immense historical value attached to Ravi Varma's works. It is the nation's wealth and so our duty to preserve it," says Shenoy. The edifice that will house the works has already been constructed in the seven-acre campus of the trust.

The archival material already collected includes a range of ancient machinery used for printing—the varnishing and the grinding machine and also more than 200 original litho stones with the impression of the works of Ravi Varma. His world renowned Saraswati and Lakshmi can be seen here, along with rarer works like portraits of the empress and the emperor of England and the beautiful Mohini on a swing. There are also many five kg packets of special ink powders in various colours used for the production of these works. These



PICTURE PERFECT: Shenoy (top); Ravi Varma's pioneering printing press and signed oleographs in their original frames (right); powder colour bags (extreme right)



packets were imported from Germany before the turn of the previous century, still retain their original packaging and labels and the bright colours, in spite of having been exposed to the vagaries of nature in Malavli. The oleographs of paintings, sketches, drawing and worksheets will form the core of the museum. "There is enough here to write many books," he says. And this is reflected in scores of prints, from his images that have been used to illustrate everything from commercials for Gripe Water, to Sunlight soap to snuff boxes.

The bigger spin off was that Ravi Varma style of oleographs influenced a range of artists from S.M. Pandit to Dhurandhar to several other nameless artists, who blindly followed his style. And, the grand moment came when

the nationalist moment in India borrowed on the Ravi Varma style to create art work with Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru, and Bharat Mata came to be immortalised by Ravi Varma's image robed in red with four weaponed hands. The images gave rise to more illustration, like Bharat Mata blessing Shivaji or Netaji by bestowing weapons on them. "What does India have in common in terms of a cultural identity?" asks Shenoy, who believes that it "was Ravi Varma's prints that culturally unified India, from Kashmir to Kanyakumari."

Ravi Varma always appealed to the classes with his princely background and his artistic approach, besides his fascination for European Art.

However, it was due to the printing press that he managed to break out of the ivory tower to reach the teeming masses in India. Shenoy hopes that the archival material will revive an interest in the great artists and initiate a whole new generation to study his works. "What is all this after all, but a tangible slice of history that must be preserved for posterity," says Shenoy. He has been approached by some private collectors from India and abroad, who want to add to the good work by donating Ravi Varma's original works to the trust. The latest in this direction is the announcement by filmmaker Ketan Mehta that his new film will be based on the artist's works, another slice of history documented through another art form, but all adding to the legacy the artist so richly deserves. ■